we agree we'll have a second summit next year and hold it in the United States? I hereby invite you."

"I accept," Gorbachev replied, then, with hardly a pause, he said: "But you've never seen the Soviet Union." I said, "No," and he said, "Well, then let's hold a third summit in the Soviet Union. You come to Moscow."

"I accept," I said.

Our people couldn't believe it when I told them what had happened. Everything was settled for two more summits. They hadn't dreamed it was possible.

I understood the irony of what happened that morning under the overcast Geneva sky. I had spent much of my life sounding a warning about the threat of Communism to America and the rest of the Free World. Political opponents had called me a saber rattler and a right-wing extremist. I'd called the Soviet Union an "evil empire."

Now, here I was opening negotiations with the Kremlin, and, while doing so, I had extended my hand with warmth and a smile to its highest leader.

Yet I knew I hadn't changed. If anything, the world was changing, and it was changing for the better. The world was approaching the threshold of a new day. We had a chance to make it a safer, better place for now and the twenty-first century.

There was much more to be done, but we had laid a foundation in Geneva.

As Nancy and I flew home to Washington two days later, I had some time to look back on the journey that had taken me to Geneva.

I had to admit that it had been a long journey from Dixon, Illinois, and Davenport, Iowa.